

Brazil, Decoded

A cultural guide for international executives

Eight cultural patterns behind the Brazilian market, the companies that read them well, and the businesses that paid for missing them.

Finding your place in Brazil

Every arrival in a new country begins with a search for space: where to live, where to set up the business, where daily life will happen. One premise helps before that choice. No country has a single, homogeneous culture.

China, Italy and Brazil each hold many cultures that share a history and some common traits. Every region, city and neighbourhood combines those traits in its own way.

Stereotypes are a useful starting point. Brazilians are said to be loud, and in many places that holds. Calling a bar or restaurant *badalado* is praise: it means busy, lively, full of people talking loudly, one of the country's favourite ways to relax. Brazil also has calm, quiet places made for rest and reflection. They exist in every city; finding them takes knowing where to look.

The state of São Paulo alone has humid, cooler mountain towns and hotter inland cities on the Western São Paulo Plateau, known for its red *terra roxa* soil and coffee farms. It has metropolises and small towns, and places tied to particular traditions, communities and niches.

In almost any of them you can choose your way of life: quieter or more urban, with more or less security infrastructure, closer to street life or more private, on foot or by car. That choice becomes far easier with someone who lays out the options and reads them with you.

The same reasoning applies to business. A product or service enters Brazil through a whole chain of relationships: the factory, the distributor, the retailer, the consumer, the professionals who recommend, install and repair it, the technical and academic knowledge of the sector, everyday habits, and even the workarounds every culture has.

Knowing whether your product can become part of people's routines means knowing these places and these people. Part of the answer comes early, through research and listening; part only comes through testing.

How to use this guide

1. **What you'll notice** — the everyday signs of each cultural pattern.
2. **The evidence** — companies that succeeded or failed, with figures checked against published sources (numbered, listed on page 13).
3. **For your market entry** — the practical implication for strategy.
4. **In the room** — how the same pattern shows up in meetings, negotiations and relationships.

Passages marked *Our reading* are Live & Learn Brazil's cultural interpretation of the facts, offered as analysis.

About this guide. This guide was developed with the support of artificial intelligence for research and drafting. Every figure, source and interpretation was reviewed, curated and analysed by the Live & Learn Brazil team.

Eight cultural axes, eight business lessons

Each axis links a daily habit to a measurable business outcome.

	CULTURAL AXIS	COMPANY EVIDENCE	KEY FIGURE
01	Sweetness, affection and memory	Nestlé Leite Moça	Sold since 1890; the brand name came from consumers' own nickname
02	Coffee and hospitality	Melitta	Paper filters launched in 1968 in a cloth-filter country
03	Neighbourhood, referral and personal ties	Home Depot (Chile, Argentina) · Gurgel · Leroy Merlin	Home Depot sold all 9 South American stores in 2001; Gurgel bankrupt in 1994
04	The masonry house in a tropical climate	Electric shower · home-product design	Mains voltage varies by city: 127 V or 220 V
05	Autonomy and material ingenuity	Fortlev · electronic security sector	312.5 million water-supply interruptions in 2022; R\$ 16 bn security market in 2025
06	Trust through an easy way out	Mercado Livre	Brazil ≈ 52% of group net revenue
07	The shopping routine	Walmart Brasil	Supermarket revenue –18% (2013–16); 59 stores closed
08	Sociability, shared space and status	JBL · Havaianas	JBL holds 83% of portable speakers; Havaianas 4 bn+ pairs sold

The common thread

Across all eight axes, winners did three things: they listened to how Brazilians already used the category, adapted the product or format to that habit, and built trust through the people around the purchase. Those who imported a model unchanged paid for it in years of losses.

Sweetness, affection and memory

In Brazil, sweets carry affection: a grandmother's kitchen, birthday parties, childhood. The taste has deep roots in the colonial sugar-cane economy and runs through regional cuisines across the country.

What you'll notice

- Desserts noticeably sweeter than in Europe or Asia.
- *Brigadeiros* at every birthday, for children and adults alike.
- Coffee often served already sweetened.
- Homemade sweets offered to visitors as a welcome.

In the room

Accept the sweet offered at the end of a visit or meeting. Asking about a regional dessert is an easy, warm way into conversation.

SUCCESS - FOREIGN BRAND

Nestlé Leite Moça

Condensed milk reached Brazil in 1890 as the imported "Milkmaid". Consumers struggled with the English name and called it *leite da moça*, "the maid's milk", after the girl on the label. When Nestlé opened its first Brazilian factory in Araras (São Paulo) in 1921, it adopted the consumers' nickname as the brand.^{1,2}

1890

first sold in Brazil,
imported from
Switzerland

1921

local production
begins in Araras (SP)

1940s

the *brigadeiro* is
created with the
product

Recipes printed on the label moved it from pharmacies to kitchens, and it became the base of the national dessert repertoire.²

THE LESSON INSIDE THE SUCCESS

The can without recipes

In 2004 Nestlé introduced a curved can without the paper label and its printed recipes. It did not catch on; consumers asked for the recipes back, and the brand restored them.³

Our reading: the recipe on the can carried family memory. Removing it removed part of the product.

FOR YOUR MARKET ENTRY

A foreign product gains ground when it fits a taste and a memory that already exist. Ask which recipe, occasion or family ritual your product can join, and listen to the names customers give it.

Coffee and hospitality

The *cafezinho* is a key that opens the door to trust. It is offered to visitors at home, at a company's reception, in workshops and in offices, often several times a day.

What you'll notice

- Coffee brewed in the morning and kept in a thermos flask all day, ready for whoever arrives.
- Small cups, frequent offers, often pre-sweetened.
- Brewed, filtered coffee as the everyday standard at home.

In the room

Accept the coffee, and compliment it. Praising the coffee a host offers signals that you value their hospitality, and it often opens conversations a formal agenda would not.

SUCCESS · FOREIGN BRAND

Melitta

The German company opened a subsidiary in São Paulo in 1968 to sell paper filters and filter holders, in a country where the cloth filter was a household tradition.⁴ The paper filter kept the familiar gesture of straining coffee and added convenience and hygiene.

1968

arrival in Brazil with paper filters and holders

1980

launches Brazil's first vacuum-packed coffee

1995–99

adds cappuccino, espresso beans and thermos flasks

Melitta then moved into roasting and packaging, following the ritual from filter to cup to flask.⁵

Our reading: the innovation kept the gesture Brazilians already loved and improved the experience around it. Innovations that ask people to abandon a ritual travel far more slowly.

FOR YOUR MARKET ENTRY

Coffee is both a market and a language. Products that respect the ritual of brewed, shared coffee have an open path, and executives who accept and value the coffee they are offered build rapport faster.

Neighbourhood, referral and personal ties

Referrals and personal relationships often weigh as much as the brand. The logic crosses all income levels: from the neighbourhood mechanic to the family lawyer or real-estate broker, Brazilians buy through people they trust.

What you'll notice

- Small neighbourhood stores (*depósitos*) thriving next to big chains, often with informal credit.
- Homeowners hire a mason or electrician instead of doing it themselves.
- "Who do you recommend?" as the first step of most purchases.

FAILURE · REGIONAL BENCHMARK

Home Depot in South America

The US do-it-yourself giant never operated in Brazil. It entered Chile and Argentina in the late 1990s and in 2001 sold all nine stores: five in Chile to its partner Falabella, four in Argentina to Jumbo, owner of Easy.^{6,7}

9

stores sold in 2001

CLP 658m

loss in Chile in the first half of 2001 alone

Our reading: the model assumed customers would renovate their own homes, in a region where people hire a professional.

In the room

Warm introductions open doors that cold outreach does not. Ask for introductions, and expect first meetings to focus on getting to know each other.

FAILURE · BRAZILIAN INNOVATION

Gurgel

The Brazilian carmaker launched the BR-800 in 1988 with a tax advantage. In 1990 the incentive was extended to every car up to 1.0 litre, and Fiat's Uno Mille arrived at a similar price with more space and power.⁸ Gurgel went bankrupt in 1994.⁹

Our reading: neighbourhood mechanics knew the Uno and its parts; the Gurgel needed rare parts and know-how.

ADAPTATION

Leroy Merlin

The French retailer kept its DIY message and added Obramax, a cash-and-carry for construction professionals.¹⁰

FOR YOUR MARKET ENTRY

Map who recommends, installs and repairs your product. A product that the neighbourhood professional knows and trusts circulates much faster.

The masonry house in a tropical climate

Brazilian homes are built with brick, concrete and plaster, and this building culture shapes what a home product can be. The workforce is trained in masonry, while drywall and timber systems find few specialists, and the sector also faces a labour shortage.

What you'll notice

- No central heating, and hot-water pipes only in higher-end buildings.
- An electric shower head in almost every bathroom, with wiring close to the water.
- Water tanks on the roof feeding taps by gravity (see Axis 05).

In the room

On a site visit, talk to the team. Masons and electricians are respected sources of practical knowledge, and their opinion shapes what clients buy.

LOCAL SOLUTION

The electric shower

With mild winters across most of the country, there was never demand for central heating. Standard plumbing uses PVC pipes for cold water; hot-water piping (copper, CPVC, PPR) appears mainly in higher-end construction.

The electric shower heats water at the point of use, works with the low pressure of rooftop tanks, costs little and can be installed by any electrician. Decades of relatively cheap hydroelectric power helped make it the standard.

Foreign visitors are often alarmed by the wiring near the water. The device is designed for it, with an insulated heating element and grounding; the real risk comes from improvised installation.

WATCH POINT

Voltage and standards

Mains voltage in Brazil varies by city: 127 V in some, 220 V in others, sometimes both in the same building. Plugs follow a national standard of their own.

Our reading: many imported appliances and building systems fail on details like these before they ever reach the question of price.

FOR YOUR MARKET ENTRY

Before launching a home product, check how it works with Brazilian construction, electrical and plumbing standards, and with the skills of the professionals who will install it.

Autonomy and material ingenuity

Faced with unreliable public services, Brazilian households build their own guarantees at home. From this need comes an ingenuity with materials: simple, affordable, clever solutions that became national standards.

What you'll notice

- Blue water tanks on almost every roof.
- Gas cylinders delivered to the kitchen by truck.
- Walls, gates, electric fences, guard booths and doormen around homes and buildings.

In the room

Visible security is normal in offices and residential buildings. Expect ID checks at reception and allow extra minutes before meetings.

SUCCESS - BRAZILIAN COMPANY

Water tanks and Fortlev

Under Brazilian standards, mains water rises to a household tank and flows down to the taps, with a reserve for at least 24 hours of consumption.¹¹ The reason is intermittent supply.¹² Market leader Fortlev was founded in Espírito Santo in 1989.¹³

312.5m

water-supply interruptions recorded in Brazil in 2022

91.5%

of those interruptions in the Northeast

24 h

minimum household reserve under the standard

GROWTH MARKET

Private security

Buildings and gated communities invest in their own protection, following the same logic of autonomy.¹⁴

R\$ 16 bn+

electronic security revenue in 2025

+18.8%

growth forecast for 2026

57%

of providers list condominiums and small shops among main markets

FOR YOUR MARKET ENTRY

Products that guarantee independence from infrastructure failures find broad demand: storage, backup, protection and smart improvisation.

Trust through an easy way out

Brazilian consumers take risks when they know they can reach a person and undo the deal. The guarantee of a simple return often weighs as much as the price.

What you'll notice

- Customer service through WhatsApp, with real people answering.
- Buyers checking seller ratings before any online purchase.
- Strong consumer-protection culture, with Procon offices in every state.

In the room

Availability builds confidence. Quick, personal replies, often by WhatsApp, reassure partners as much as a contract clause does.

SUCCESS · FOREIGN BRAND

Mercado Livre

Founded in Buenos Aires in 1999, the marketplace entered Brazil when buying from strangers online felt risky. It built trust in layers: protected payment through Mercado Pago, which holds funds until delivery; public seller reputations; and, later, fast logistics with simple returns.

≈ 52%

of group net revenue comes from Brazil¹⁵

US\$ 21 bn

consolidated net revenue in 2024¹⁶

R\$ 34 bn

record investment planned in Brazil for 2025¹⁷

Our reading: each layer lowered the cost of being wrong. Once buyers knew they could undo a purchase, they bought more often.

FOR YOUR MARKET ENTRY

Reduce the risk your customer perceives. Accessible service, a clear exchange policy and returns without bureaucracy often convert better than discounts.

The shopping routine: deals, instalments, proximity

Brazilians hunt for deals, pay in instalments and spread their shopping across several places: bakery, butcher, street market, neighbourhood grocer. Many make that circuit on foot or by public transport.

What you'll notice

- Weekly promotional flyers and "offer days" for specific products.
- Prices shown as instalments: "10x R\$ 49".
- Daily trips to the bakery; weekly trips to the street market.

In the room

Payment terms are part of the price conversation. Expect instalments and deadlines to be negotiated alongside the headline number.

FAILURE · FOREIGN BRAND

Walmart Brasil (1995–2018)

Walmart bet on fixed low prices and large stores in a country that shops by promotion, close to home and often without a car, and it never turned its regional chains into a single operation.

–18%

supermarket revenue, 2013–2016¹⁸

59

stores closed in the same period¹⁸

80%

stake sold to Advent in 2018; renamed Grupo BIG¹⁹

Retail analysts point to the imported "Everyday Low Price" policy as a central mistake.¹⁸ French rivals Carrefour and Casino adapted to Brazilians' habit of shopping around for the best deals.²⁰ Early product mixes even included snow boots and golf clubs.²¹

Our reading: the format asked customers to change their routine. Competitors built around it.

FOR YOUR MARKET ENTRY

Store format and payment terms matter as much as the product. Visible promotions, instalments and presence along the customer's daily route make the difference.

Sociability, shared space and status

Brazil has an intense public cultural life (street carnival, June festivals, samba circles) that grows mostly from communities and families. Permanent public leisure infrastructure is scarcer, so social life has moved into malls, condominium clubs, backyards and rooftops.

What you'll notice

- Shopping malls working as the city's safe public square.
- Condominiums with party rooms, barbecue areas and pools.
- Music played out loud on beaches, at barbecues and in bars.

SUCCESS - FOREIGN BRAND

JBL

JBL's speaker is present at the beach, the barbecue and the rooftop party. Its Brazilian team refused to launch global products without local testing and created products of its own.²²

83%

share of portable speakers in Brazil (GfK), JBL's highest anywhere

15,000+

points of sale in the country

60%+

global share of the PartyBox line, created in Brazil

In the room

A lively, noisy restaurant signals a good place. An invitation to a barbecue or family dinner is a sign the relationship is moving forward; accept it.

SUCCESS - BRAZILIAN BRAND

Havaianas

Launched in 1962 and long seen as a cheap sandal, Havaianas launched the single-colour Top line in 1994, inspired by customers who flipped the sole to get one colour. The sandal became a symbol of Brazilian style.²³

4 bn+

pairs sold in Brazil and abroad

116

countries

520

exclusive stores

FOR YOUR MARKET ENTRY

Products linked to gatherings and to status find strong demand. Whoever offers a safe space to be together, or an object people display with pride, sells more than a function.

Business etiquette essentials

In Brazil, business follows relationship. These field practices help you build the bond that makes negotiations flow.

Greeting

A firm handshake, eye contact and a smile. Between acquaintances, men may add a hug or a pat on the shoulder, and women often greet with a kiss on the cheek. Follow the other person's lead.

Conversation first

Family, food, football and travel open most meetings. Going straight to the agenda can read as cold; a few minutes of conversation build the trust the agenda needs.

Coffee

Accept it and compliment it. The *cafezinho* is an act of hospitality, and valuing it is valuing your host.

Meals

Business lunches are long and relational. Much of the real alignment happens at the table, after the formal meeting.

Names and titles

First names come quickly. *Doutor* or *Doutora* is still used as a mark of respect for lawyers, physicians and senior figures.

Reading “yes” and “no”

Direct refusals are usually softened. “*Vamos ver*” (“let’s see”) may mean no. Read the tone and follow up personally.

WhatsApp

The main channel for business as well as personal life, including voice messages. A quick reply signals commitment.

Time

Business meetings in São Paulo tend to start on time or close to it; social events run on a more flexible clock. Traffic is a shared, accepted reason for delay; send a message.

Language

Portuguese is the language of business. A few words of it are warmly received; assuming Spanish is spoken is a common misstep.

Continuity

Relationships belong to people as much as to companies. When a contact changes, a personal handover protects the trust built so far.

Sources

1. Nestlé Brasil — Leite Moça press release. [nestle.com.br](https://www.nestle.com.br)
2. Nestlé Professional — “Moça é sinônimo de leite condensado”. [nestleprofessional.com.br/marcas/moca](https://www.nestleprofessional.com.br/marcas/moca)
3. Tribuna PR — “Leite condensado faz 100 anos no Brasil” (2021). [tribunapr.com.br](https://www.tribunapr.com.br)
4. Melitta Brasil — “Sobre a Melitta”. [melitta.com.br/institucional/sobre-melitta](https://www.melitta.com.br/institucional/sobre-melitta)
5. Folha PE — “Melitta Bentz, criadora do filtro de papel”. [folha.pe.com.br](https://www.folha.pe.com.br)
6. VMSD — “Home Depot Leaves South America” (2001). [vmsd.com](https://www.vmsd.com)
7. Emol — “Falabella materializa compra de Home Depot em Chile” (2001). [emol.com](https://www.emol.com)
8. Revista Pesquisa FAPESP — “The history of a brand”. revista.pesquisa.fapesp.br
9. Carlider — “Gurgel BR-800: o pequeno urbano brasileiro” (2016). blog.carlider.com.br
10. Exame — “Dona da Leroy Merlin traz duas novas redes para o Brasil” (2017). exame.com
11. ACE-Guarulhos — “Reservatórios domiciliares de água potável”. [aceguarulhos.com.br](https://www.aceguarulhos.com.br)
12. Brasil de Fato — “Acesso humano à água: por que precisamos falar sobre intermitência” (2024). brasildefato.com.br
13. Brasiline — Fortlev case. [brasiline.com.br/cases/fortlev](https://www.brasiline.com.br/cases/fortlev)
14. NetSeg — Pesquisa Panorama Abese 2025/2026. [netseg.com.br](https://www.netseg.com.br)
15. TI Inside — “Mercado Livre vai aportar mais de R\$ 23 bilhões no Brasil em 2024”. [tiinside.com.br](https://www.tiinside.com.br)
16. Revista Varejo Brasil — Mercado Livre Q4 2024 results. [revisavarejobrasil.com.br](https://www.revisavarejobrasil.com.br)
17. Consumidor Moderno — “Mercado Livre investe R\$ 34 bilhões no Brasil” (2025). [consumidormoderno.com.br](https://www.consumidormoderno.com.br)
18. SA Varejo — “Walmart no Brasil: por que deu errado?” (2018). [savarejo.com.br](https://www.savarejo.com.br)
19. Propmark — “Walmart sofre com falta de integração e deixa o Brasil” (2019). [propmark.com.br](https://www.propmark.com.br)
20. Exame — “Estratégia de preço da Walmart fracassa entre brasileiros” (2014). exame.com
21. Gazeta do Povo — “O que deu errado com o Walmart no Brasil” (2018). [gazetadopovo.com.br](https://www.gazetadopovo.com.br)
22. Exame — “Como o Brasil virou peça-chave global da JBL” (Oct 2025). exame.com
23. Meio & Mensagem — “Havaianas: as pegadas que todos querem seguir”. marcas.meioemensagem.com.br/havaianas

Method. This guide was developed with the support of artificial intelligence for research and drafting. Every figure, source and interpretation was reviewed, curated and analysed by the Live & Learn Brazil team.

Figures reflect the most recent published data available in September 2026. Cultural interpretations marked “Our reading” and the etiquette guidance reflect Live & Learn Brazil’s field experience. Markets change quickly; confirm figures before using them in investment decisions.

Read the culture before you enter the market

Live & Learn Brazil supports executives and multinationals arriving in São Paulo with executive relocation, high-value real-estate advisory and intercultural due diligence. We map the cultural channels through which your product and your team can circulate, supported by a network of relationships across Brazilian society.

Listening

We hear your team, partners and the local market to understand where your product meets Brazilian habits.

Workshop

We bring cultural patterns into practice for your leaders: negotiation, hospitality, relationships.

Debrief

We deliver findings and recommendations for your market entry and your people's arrival.